

*An Organizational Sociology of Education: Using Structural, Network, and Ecological Perspectives to Study Schools**

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Highlighting changes in education and organizational theorizing since the 1950s, this review integrates three perspectives for an organizational sociology of education. The structural perspective focuses on how the formal organization of resources, relationships, and information can influence student outcomes and inequalities through opportunities to learn. The network perspective highlights the role of informal interactions and interpretation as well as social and cultural capital to bring about changes. The ecological perspective illustrates how schools are affected by other schools (horizontal dimension), the educational bureaucracy (vertical dimension), and organizations outside schools (community dimension). An organizational perspective can concretize often abstract sociological topics on stratification, social reproduction, and socialization. The perspective can also reconceptualize often individualistic views on contemporary education issues like student well-being, teacher shortage, racial inequalities, and school politics. The review ends with a discussion on how to incorporate these organizational perspectives and how they can complement current studies in education, sociology, and public policy.

In studying education, a particular perspective has subtly and slowly dominated over the years as another perspective has receded or even disappeared from focus. What has won out was the human capital view highlighting how education influences knowledge and skills, how policy should invest on programs that increase such capital, and how research should understand program effects (Becker 1964; Hanushek 2019; Lucas Jr. 2015). What has lost was the organizational view that interrogated the politics of teaching (Lortie 1975), the bureaucratization of schools (Bidwell 1965, 1987, 2001), and the school as a socializing organization (Bowles and Gintis 1976; Parsons 1959). Many reasons can be proffered for this recession of the organizational perspective: the dominance of production function models that view schools as firms producing student learning, the financial support of government agencies and philanthropies for randomized controlled trials and quasi-experiments, the move of organizational theorists from sociology departments to business schools, the widespread use of standards and assessments, and the inability to engage with practical policies in favor of more abstract conceptualization in classic theories like new institutionalism, population ecology, and resource dependence (Hannan and Freeman 1977; Meyer and Rowan 1977; Pfeffer and Salancik 1978). More historically, these changes have also been outcomes of the larger push for educational equality as in *Brown v. Board of Education*, and economic changes to a knowledge economy focused on skills acquisition and human capital investment (Hanushek 2019; Mehta and Davies 2018; Ray 2019). Despite, and also because of, this recession of an organizational perspective, this article attempts to provide a framework that researchers and policymakers can use in thinking about schools and the education system more organizationally.

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Practically, a number of contemporary concerns illustrate how organizational sociology can be a key lens to interrogate issues and problems in education: Teacher shortage and turnover can be explained through an organizational view of schools as *workplaces* and teaching as a *profession* (Carver-Thomas et al. 2022; Ingersoll 2001). The concern about student well-being and chronic absenteeism can be understood as an *organizational failure* of information and engagement (Balfanz and Byrnes 2018). Socioeconomic and racial inequalities can be explained with organizational theories on *opportunity hoarding* and *status hierarchies* (Tomaskovic-Devey and Avent-Holt 2019). The culture war over curriculum and banned books can be understood as arising from *political, institutional, and ecological factors* (Trinidad 2023). By understanding how organizations work internally and how they interact with other organizations in society, education researchers can better explain educational problems, and policymakers can pinpoint specific places for organizational intervention.

Theoretically, the current focus on the micro-level of individuals and the macro-level of policies and social forces—that fails to attend to the meso-level of school organization—can be problematic. First, studies of social policies and macrosocial forces run the risk of overly deterministic answers if they ignore how policies are variably interpreted and implemented, and how forces are reified and contested, within organizations. Second, studies that are not attentive to the organizational system run the risk of explaining educational problems through individual deficiencies in teacher or student attributes, rather than through the proximal systems these individuals experience. Third, both macro- and micro-sociological studies can rob individuals of their agency, such that social forces “act on” the individual when these individuals must be seen as actors that have organizational agency: interpreting policies, resisting social forces, interacting with others, and mobilizing social and cultural resources. An organizational perspective can help researchers view topics like inequality, segregation, racism, and policy intervention not as abstract social forces but as proximate and relational processes that happen within and across organizations. Discussing these ideas on intra- and inter-organizational contexts can highlight the role of individuals as active agents, who are at times constrained by organizational structures while at other times supported by them.

Despite the practical and theoretical importance of studying schools as organizations, studies are often scattered across literatures and subfields like school improvement, professions, new institutionalism, and leadership studies. While the multiplicity of perspectives suggests the theoretical potentials of the field, it poses a pragmatic and analytical challenge that beckons clarity through synthesis. Moreover, previous attempts at synthesis (see Arum 2000; Bidwell 1965, 2001; Meyer 1977) need updating given immense educational changes over the past 20 years: the rise of school choice, outcomes-based accountability, global testing regimes, data-driven technologies, for-profit education industries, civil society participation, and challenges brought by COVID-19 (Mehta and Davies 2018; Renzulli 2014; Trinidad 2020). Because of this need for synthesis and updating, I propose an integrated framework for an *organizational sociology of education*, which I argue can be understood through structural, network, and ecological perspectives.

The first section illustrates a short history of organizational perspectives on schools, education, and teaching with an emphasis on three key distinctions: (1) differing organizational agents and goals, (2) formal versus informal elements, and (3) internal versus external environment. This section ends with the proposed integrated framework. The second section focuses on the formal organizational structure, where the structuring of *resources*,

relationships, and *information* can have consequences on students' opportunities to learn, which can then influence various student outcomes. The third section highlights the informal organizational networks, inclusive of *interactions and interpretation* on one side as well as *social and cultural capital* on the other. The fourth section highlights the ecological perspective as schools are affected by other schools (*horizontal dimension*), various levels of school bureaucracy (*vertical dimension*), and organizations outside schools (*community dimension*). The fifth section highlights practical ideas for researchers to use in their study of schools as organizations. Although research and examples are mainly drawn from K-12 education in the United States, the theoretical concepts may be adapted to other contexts, to higher education, and to other organizations.

How can an integrated framework help our study of schools, society, and inequality? This article primarily provides a shared vocabulary to theorize and integrate what scholars know from various subfields of education, sociology, political science, and organizational studies. This article notes the importance of an organizational sociology of education to complement current ways of studying schools and the education system. To complement sociological studies of stratification, an organizational perspective can illustrate proximal organizational processes and structures that lead to inequalities. To complement economists' randomized controlled trials, this perspective can interrogate implementation, sensemaking, resistance, and buy-in. To complement studies of policy effectiveness, an organizational perspective can illustrate hidden dynamics of competing interests and political (in)feasibility. To complement program evaluations, it can reveal ecological, institutional, and spillover effects of organizational actions, decisions, and interventions. The article proposes the ways this perspective can enrich education, sociology, and organizational studies.

Historically Situating the Organizational Sociology of Education

To understand the organizational sociology of education, one must recognize the historical changes and developments both in schools and in organizational studies. A first place to start is to interrogate the various *agents* in the school and their *goals*. While much of contemporary literature has focused on the school's role in instruction with students gaining cognitive and non-cognitive skills (Biesta 2009; Dreeben 2002), this goal has not always remained the same. In the classic article "The School Class as a Social System," Talcott Parsons (1959) argued that the school acted to socialize children into the values of society. In this functionalist view, the school's goal is to train youths to participate in a society valuing meritocracy and equality of opportunity. However, this perspective had been challenged by research on how schooling reproduces inequalities, particularly as education and its attendant tracking of students replicate hierarchical division of labor (Bowles and Gintis 1976). In this view of education as a system of allocation, schools confer success on some and failure on others. Organizational theorist John W. Meyer (1977) challenged these individualist conceptions by showing education's larger effect on society rather than just the individual. He suggested that education was a legitimating institution, changing the distribution of "political, economic, and social positions in society" (Meyer 1977:56). Economist Gary Becker (1964) had suggested the idea of schools being key places to receive investments in people's "human capital"—which has led to the view of education's primary function being the promotion of human capital to advance economically in society (Hanushek 2019). Taken together, the scholarly understanding of the organization of schools has changed and shifted with the institution's varying and at times competing goals.

Another set of actors key to the system are teachers. In understanding the school as workplace, early theories have highlighted the hierarchical-bureaucratic nature of schools as well as their “structural looseness,” as teachers worked autonomously from each other (Bidwell 1965:976). In his classic book *Schoolteacher*, sociologist Dan C. Lortie (1975) used the metaphor of an egg-crate to show how the structure of teachers in separate classrooms can lead to this structural looseness. In addition to physical looseness, the school has also been characterized as “loosely coupled,” where public displays for legitimacy do not align with what actually happens on the ground (Weick 1976). Sociologist Richard M. Ingersoll (1996) noted the power of teachers, both to collectively influence policy and to individually appropriate or resist policies in their classrooms. However, the advent of test-based accountability regimes has challenged this power as schools experienced recoupling, or “the process of creating tight couplings where loose couplings were once in place” (Hallett 2010:54). In this way, teachers transformed their work by practicing organizational routines that aligned with public expectations (Spillane, Parise, and Sherer 2011). More recently, the creation of professional learning communities among teachers has further broken down the structural looseness that has originally characterized the profession (Bryk, Gomez, and Grunow 2011). A potential change, however, may come to the profession as education grapples with issues of teacher shortage and turnover (Carver-Thomas et al. 2022).

Aside from shifts in the goals for students and the environment for teachers, other educational actors have also experienced key shifts. Given local control of schools, principals do not just implement district mandates; they also have to balance competing political demands from various stakeholders (White, Evans, and Malin 2023). More than individuals employed by the school, the ecosystem now includes coaches and support staff that the school or district contracts with (Woulfin, Stevenson, and Lord 2023), school resource officers that have functioned like police and security guards at the same time (Counts et al. 2018), and other supplementary education service providers (Burch 2009). Beyond these individuals, organizations have also expanded with the larger influence of research partnerships, philanthropies, and advocacy organizations (Coburn, Penuel, and Farrell 2021; Scott 2009; Trinidad 2023). For example, these organizations’ material and financial support for particular policies have affected their enactment (Reckhow, Tompkins-Stange, and Galey-Horn 2021) while local community involvement has influenced school changes and student outcomes (Epstein 2008). Although scholars have often distinguished between internal and external actors in education, recent studies have suggested the blurring of boundaries between these two, as traditionally internal actors like teachers hold non-school functions and traditionally external actors like parents take on more roles in schools (Lubienski, Yemini, and Maxwell 2022). Changes in the agents and goals of schools highlight the need to understand the current complexity of organizations.

A second place to historically situate the study of organizations is to distinguish between formal and informal elements. Formal structures include rules, routines, processes, division of labor, organizational structures, policies, and procedures that support the goal of the organization (Scott 2003). Taylor’s (1911) scientific management and Weber’s (1978) theory of bureaucracy draw on this rational understanding of organizations. Williamson (1981) furthered this perspective by looking at the way organizational decisions are made to reduce transaction costs, or the “costs” of planning, deciding, changing plans, etc.—which then highlights a rational economic way of thinking about organizations. However, these perspectives have been challenged by theorists who gave greater importance to

interpersonal interactions and informal systems (Scott 2003). In the natural systems perspective, the focus is on organizational behavior and implementation (Mayo 1933), sensemaking (Brown, Colville, and Pye 2015; Weick, Sutcliffe, and Obstfeld 2005), social capital, social networks, and interpersonal relationships (Burt 2004; Lin 2001), and resistance and unanticipated consequences (Merton 1936). I take inspiration from these previous studies by highlighting the dynamic interaction between formal and informal elements, between what I refer to in this paper as “structure” and “network.”

A third aspect for interrogating organizations is the distinction between closed and open systems’ view of organizations (Scott 2003). The previous paragraph highlighting the role of structures and networks focus on the internal aspects of an organization. However, since the 1970s, organizational theorizing has expanded the focus to the environment of the organization, and how “outside” factors impact organizational decisions, actions, survival, and success. Population ecology is concerned with changes within a given set of organizations (Carroll 1984; Hannan and Freeman 1977). Resource dependence theory studies how resources external to an organization affect the organization’s actions and decisions (Pfeffer and Salancik 1978). New institutional theory focuses on the constraining and enabling effects of formal and informal rules, that is, institutions (DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Meyer and Rowan 1977). Rather than focus on macro-sociological trends, inhabited institutionalism investigates the recursive relationships among institutions, social interactions, and organizations—bridging institutional analysis and micro-interactionism (Hallett and Hawbaker 2021). These theories highlight the greater attention to and influence of the environment, ecology, or community surrounding a school.

Drawing on changes in education (e.g., goals of schools and profession of teaching) and the shifts in the theorization of organizations (from formal and informal systems to open systems), I propose an integrated framework that brings together these ideas in the study of education. While studies investigate the school as *an* organization, I also propose understanding the *process* of organization that schools go through. This essay maps out three key perspectives in an organizational sociology of education: The structural perspective highlights how schools formally organize resources, relationships, and information—and how these facets transform opportunities to learn, which then impact outcomes and inequalities. Such research on the formal aspects of the organization is a key theme in the discipline, dating back to the work of Selznick (1948) on the formal organization as a system of consciously coordinated activities. The network perspective focuses on the actions and interactions of various agents inside the school, and how they leverage social and cultural capital to promote human capital. While I make a distinction between the formal and informal aspects, these two have a dynamic relationship as structures facilitate or prevent actions while informal networks can become solidified in new structures. The ecological perspective highlights the ecologies of schools, educational bureaucracies, neighborhoods, institutions, and industries that drive inequalities, innovations, and institutionalized practices. Figure 1 illustrates the connections among these perspectives, particularly how structures and networks reinforce each other, and how inter-organizational systems span different ecologies. At the center of the process of organization is the individual who experiences and belongs to organizational structures, networks, and ecologies. Subsequent figures will zoom into how the proximal systems of organizational structures networks can influence student outcomes through what is called in the literature as, “opportunities to learn.”

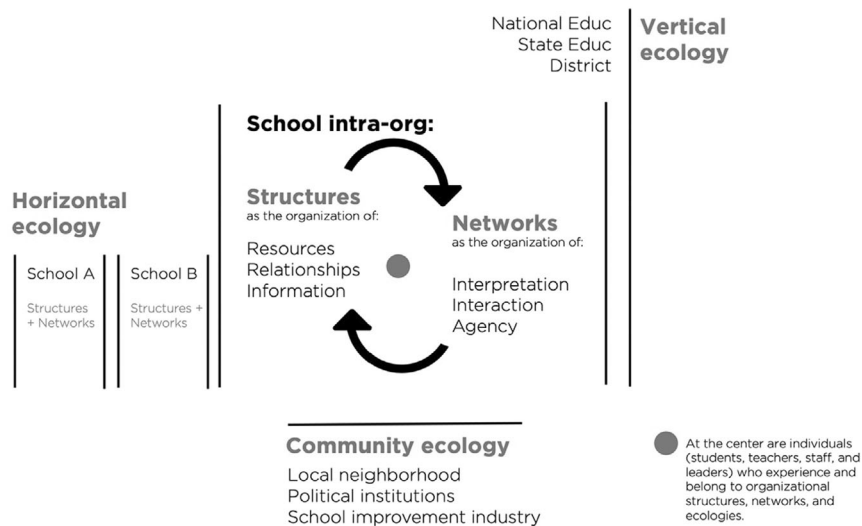


Figure 1 An integrated organizational perspective on education.

Using this organizational lens to study education alerts sociologists and education researchers to potential analytic gaps and possibilities for further research. For example, sociologists of education often study racism and inequality in education, particularly in terms of racial achievement gaps (Ewing 2018; Gillborn 2006; Noguera and Wing 2008). While many studies focus on *race* as a predictive variable to these gaps, researchers can also interrogate proximal organizational processes that contribute and institutionalize racism (Ray 2019). Studies often focus on intra-organizational structures like resource allocation and discipline practices as contributive to racial disparities (Ewing 2018; Losen 2014). Yet these formal structures are part of a larger ecology of opportunity hoarding across different schools and racial schemas shared by the wider public; structures also become realized and resisted in everyday interactions and routines of networked actors. By ignoring an integrated organizational perspective, sociologists run the risk of limiting the theoretical analysis to just one aspect of school organization.

Structural Perspective

The term *organization* can be understood as a process schools go through and the *formal structure* as the outcome of that process. The formal organizational structure in schools may involve curriculum, policies, rules, routines, leadership roles, division of labor, school size, material resource, accountability mechanisms, and many others (Bryk et al. 2015; Cohen, Raudenbush, and Ball 2003; Darling-Hammond, Ross, and Milliken 2006). To theorize and provide unity to these different school structures, I categorize them as *resource* structures, *formal relationship* structures, and *information* structures. Figure 2 suggests a conceptual model for how the formal organizational structures (resources, relationships, and information) independently and collectively influence student outcomes, primarily through their influence on students' opportunities to learn.

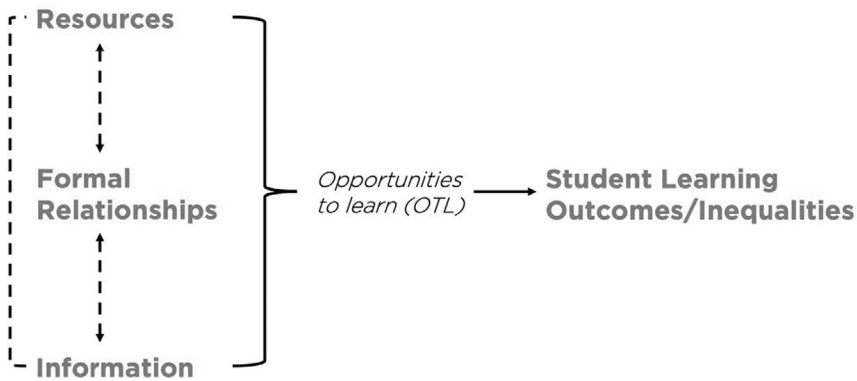


Figure 2 Structural perspective.

Assuming the goal of education is the learning of knowledge and skills, theorists like Sørensen and Hallinan (1977) have proposed that learning happens as a function of student's ability, effort, and opportunities to learn. The organizational element of "opportunities to learn" (or OTL) refers to the use of resources that contribute or prevent students' acquisition of knowledge and skills (Grodsky, Warren, and Felts 2008). The distribution of OTL is often unequally and inequitably distributed, particularly along geographical and racial lines. Moreover, OTL is often related to the curricular content's focus, rigor, and coherence rather than simply access to education (Reardon. 2019; Schmidt and Maier. 2009). Some scholars have argued, however, that what matters is not so much resources per se but the *use* of resources to contribute toward more effective instruction (Cohen, Raudenbush, and Ball 2003). Furthermore, outcomes are affected not just by *resources* but also by the formal structures of *relationships* and *information sharing*.

These structures of resources, formal relationships, and information interact with each other to dynamically influence OTL. For example, the formal organization of students into particular age-grade groupings, class sections, and ability levels can influence students' OTL through schools differentially allocating resources (Sørensen 1970). Students' assignment to more or less experienced teachers shows how the organizational form can impact OTL (Bidwell and Kasarda 1980). Finally, the organization of leadership, the struggle for power, and the flow of information are considered significant distal factors that support, enable, or threaten OTL (Spillane, Halverson, and Diamond 2001; Spillane and Healy 2010). By attending to these organizational structures, researchers can understand the aspects of the system that enable or constrain individuals' action, agency, and effectiveness.

Organizing Resources

An organizational perspective of formal structures does not only investigate resources available for students, but how these resources enable, disable, or (in)equitably allocate OTL (Grodsky, Warren, and Felts 2008). Sociologists, economists, and education policy scholars have often studied the effects of organizational policies, practices, and structures like ability grouping, length of the school day, smaller high schools, advanced placement, and unique aspects of charter schools (Bloom and Unterman 2014; Dobbie, Roland Jr., and Fryer. 2013; Downey and Condrón 2016; Gamoran et al. 1995; Golann 2015; Trinidad and King 2021).

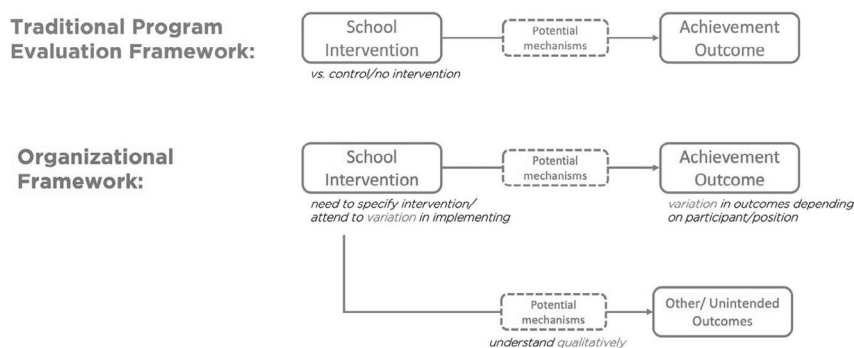


Figure 3 Differentiating traditional from organizational research on school resource structures.

A structural organizational perspective refines the theorization for the “effects” of these policies by attending to three distinct aspects: the impact of an organizational arrangement on intended outcomes, its varied and unintended consequences, and its qualitative variation in practice. The text in italics in Figure 3 note these three distinct aspects in the organizational study of school resource structures.

Although there are various ways by which schools organize resources like time, money, physical properties, and material assets, I take as a case a frequently studied aspect of organizing students into distinct ability groups or tracks that may bring varied learning opportunities consequential for maintaining, aiding, or addressing inequalities (Gamoran et al. 1995). Ability grouping in primary schools and tracking in secondary schools are practices that cluster students in distinct courses of study depending on their aptitude or ability (Domina et al. 2019). The differential allocation of time, resources, and teachers to varied students impact outcomes by influencing students’ ease in learning, teachers’ effectiveness in instruction, or the school’s efficiency amid constraints. A structural perspective interrogates three questions regarding intended, unintended, and variable outcomes.

First, *what are the intended consequences of a particular way of structuring resources?* A particular organizational arrangement like tracking is assumed to influence OTL, and consequently student outcomes like grades, standardized test scores, and learning (Hallinan 1994). Its theory of action highlights teachers being able to tailor instruction to students’ abilities, and thus lead to instructional efficiency (Steenbergen-Hu, Makel, and Olszewski-Kubilius 2016). However, opponents highlight its role in perpetuating or aggravating inequalities, particularly as low-ability students have limited access to higher ability students (Betts 2011; Trinidad and King 2021). But ability grouping has a lot of structural variations: Some schools have within-class grouping, some have subject-specific ability grouping, some have accelerated programs, and some have groups only for gifted students without hierarchically distributing regular students (see Steenbergen-Hu, Makel, and Olszewski-Kubilius 2016 for a review). Thus, the effect of ability grouping depends on specificities of how they are designed, carried out, and implemented. A structural organizational perspective should be attentive to these variations in structures as well as extensive in their description.

Second, *what are the unanticipated consequences of a particular way of structuring resources?* Sociologist Robert Merton (1936) noted that organizational policies and changes can have unanticipated and unintended consequences. Although a policy may positively impact one aspect of the organization, it may have negative aspects in another. In the case of ability grouping, qualitative studies suggest unintended consequences of teachers having lower expectations for students in low-ability classes (Bölükbaş and Gür 2020) and how resources are differentially allocated across tracks (Marks 2014). Some quantitative studies also suggest that ability grouping has a positive effect for high-ability students in “gifted classes” (Vogl and Preckel 2014) but has negative academic and psychosocial effects for those in low-ability groups (McGillicuddy and Devine 2020). Thus, an organizational perspective tries to critically interrogate other potential outcomes and changes that can be masked by effects “on average.”

Third, *what are variations in the structure and implementation?* Variations happen not only because of varied formal structures but also because of varied contexts, histories, resistance, and competing interpretations of school policies and practices. I have already noted earlier that variations in the type of tracking, whether it happens within classrooms, between classrooms, or between schools (Steenbergen-Hu, Makel, and Olszewski-Kubilius 2016). However, even within the same form of between-class tracking, outcomes may differ due to organization-specific practices like the degree of curricular differentiation among tracks, students’ mobility between tracks, and creation of skills-homogeneous classes (Domina et al. 2019). Such structural variation between organizations, too, must be understood not as a primary cause but as a proximal enabler for agency. For example, Carbonaro (2005) shows that outcomes are affected not just by the structure of where someone is placed but also by the student’s agency or effort within that specific position.

An organizational perspective attends to the intended, unintended, and variable outcomes that come from the way resources are structured. One of the key ideas in this section is the importance of attending to the subtle and minute ways by which structures differ (e.g., between-class vs. within-class ability grouping). While I concentrate on ability grouping, this perspective can be applied to other school structures: Studies on smaller schools asks if and why these schools lead to better student outcomes—with answers focused on the relationship and culture-building in these schools (Bloom and Unterman 2014; Darling-Hammond, Ross, and Milliken 2006). Studies of charter schools look at how outcomes can be attributed to specific practices of tutoring, extended school hours, and teacher incentives (Dobbie, Roland Jr., and Fryer. 2011). Finally, school programs like increasing time for algebra can have positive long-term effects but only if particular organizational arrangements are faithfully adopted (Nomi, Raudenbush, and Smith 2021). The organizational perspective helps expand the outcomes of interest (more than just to student test scores) as well as focuses on the subtle but salient aspects of the structure that can influence OTL.

Organizing Formal Relationships

In organizations, relationships are often structured through formal rules, privileges, and expectations (Scott 2003). In schools, relationships are formalized through the hierarchy in schools with principals, department chairs, coordinators, and teachers as well as through the relational dynamics between students and teachers. Many studies often focus on individual teachers’ instructional effectiveness and personal relationships with students, often ignoring the organizational arrangements and contexts that can influence their effectiveness

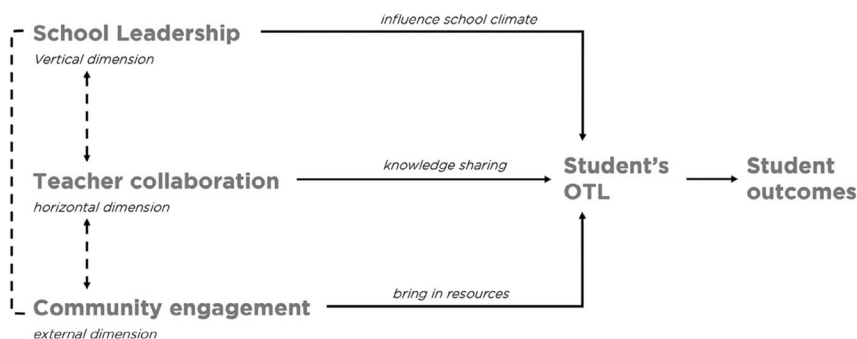


Figure 4 Organizational research on formal relationship structures.

(Ingersoll 2001; Ingersoll and Collins 2017). However, even the most qualified teacher may fail to make an impact in an unsupportive environment, while average ones may thrive in organizations supportive of instruction and well-being. This section highlights the role of the formal organization of leadership, collaboration, and community engagement in influencing OTL through changing the school climate, increasing knowledge sharing among teachers, and bringing in resources from the community. Figure 4 illustrates this dynamic with how school leadership, teacher collaboration, and community engagement can independently and collectively influence the opportunities open for students, subsequently affecting their outcomes.

Studies on principal leadership often focus on the vertical dimension of power, particularly how school outcomes are influenced by decisions regarding academic support, inclusion of curricular programs, hiring/development of staff, and shaping of organizational goals (Bryk 2010; Lee, Bryk, and Smith 1993). Studies highlight how leaders' decisions and personalities can set the pace for development and improvement (Golann 2015), or become a barrier when constituents lose faith in school leadership (Hallett 2010). However, an organizational view also looks at how the relationships of power are structured. Describing distributed leadership, Spillane et al. (2001:25) point to how "the execution of leadership tasks is often distributed among multiple leaders," suggesting the involvement of not just principals but also assistant principals, coordinators, counselors, and school board members. An organizational perspective views the consequences of different forms of distributed leadership: faculty involvement in decision-making (Ingersoll 1996), diversity and size of leadership teams (Spillane and Healy 2010), and distinct self-managed groups (Harris et al. 2007). In this way, the structure of leadership and power can create systems that impact social climate and enable better instruction (Harris et al. 2007).

More than structuring the vertical dimension of leadership and power, schools can also structure the horizontal dimension of collaboration and competition. School structures like meetings and professional development opportunities influence if and how teachers collaborate with each other (Allen and Penuel 2015; Spillane, Halverson, and Diamond 2001). District and school policies can intentionally and actively affect social networks. For example, having instructional coaches can impact teachers' access to expertise and the depth of their interaction with each other (Coburn and Russell 2008). These structured horizontal relationships are key to changes because resources and information are shared through networks

of mentorship and professional learning (Coburn, Mata, and Choi 2013; Penuel et al. 2009). For example, Tichnor-Wagner, Harrison, and Cohen-Vogel (2016) found that high value-added schools had intentional opportunities for collaboration and participatory leadership, such as cross-departmental professional learning communities, common planning time, “new teacher” meetings, and diffusion of instructional decisions to academic coaches. A key component here is the intentionality of formalizing these horizontal relationships such as when teachers coordinate instruction (Kraft et al. 2015), when peer feedbacks are routinized (Dobbie, Roland Jr., and Fryer. 2013), and when professional learning opportunities are regularly practiced (Vescio, Ross, and Adams 2008). Structuring these horizontal relationships is often dependent on the decisions and initiatives of leaders in the vertical relationship.

The formal organization of vertical and horizontal relationships within the school is also affected by how schools organize outside constituents. The school’s formalized relationship with the community (e.g., parents and civic community) has a bearing for their resources, which impact students’ OTL (Bryk 2010; Hart et al. 2020). While traditional stratification research conceives of such involvement as a result of parental networks and background characteristics (Li and Fischer 2017), some researchers have explored how formal organizational initiatives can lead to increased community engagement. For example, studies have found that parental involvement is not only predicted by family, child, and parent–teacher factors but also by school efforts like having newsletters, parent–teacher meetings, and parental training (Hornby and Blackwell 2018; Hornby and Lafaele 2011). However, a recent study on an intervention to increase parents’ engagement and social capital did not show evidence of its increasing students’ achievement (Gamoran et al. 2021). Thus, more research should attempt to understand how intentional programs targeting the community outside schools can influence OTL and subsequently student achievement.

In summary, schools organize and structure the formal relationships among individuals: vertically as power is shared or concentrated, horizontally as teachers coordinate with each other, or externally as parents and community members are engaged. These formal structures can influence students’ OTL as relational systems can impact school climate, improve knowledge sharing, and bring about additional resources.

Organizing Information

Information is crucial not only as a means of measuring performance but also as a way of changing it. Studies on school accountability, teacher evaluation, and student monitoring have shown how data do not simply provide information; they change organizational processes and priorities as well (Mennicken and Espeland 2019). In schools, the organization of information is a political process that has consequences not only for measuring to improve systems but also for motivating behavior change among individuals (e.g., teachers). These then have consequences for students’ OTL, and research has shown both positive and negative consequences for the various ways information is leveraged. Figure 5 shows that school systems and students’ opportunities to learn are influenced by how measures are used to improve systems as well as by how these metrics are used to influence or change behavior. More distantly, these measures and metrics are influenced by the politics of information regarding what are measured and not measured.

Information is a political process. Data are not merely products of rational calculation; they are the result of a process of organizational actors determining and negotiating what actually counts. Policy makers determine accountability measures, school leaders

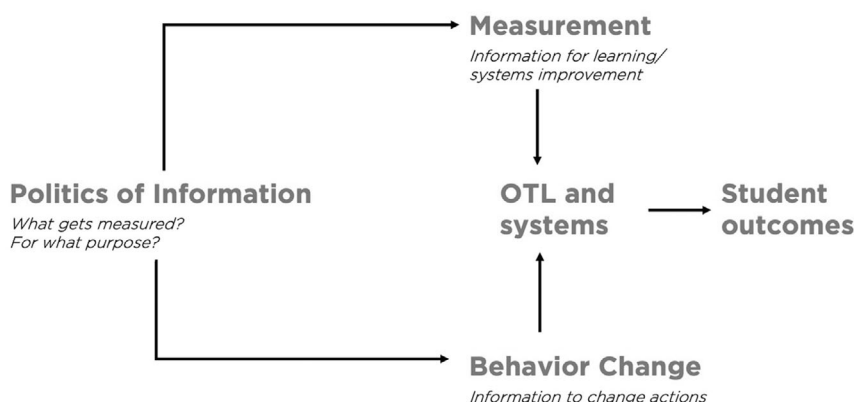


Figure 5 Organizational research on information structures.

design routines for data use, and teachers share data with each other—whether on student performance or teaching practice (Coburn and Turner 2012). Information is institutionalized when school actors organize routines and structures that encourage the everyday use of data (Spillane 2012). As an example, schools and district offices often process data with each other through reciprocal information flows, capacity building for using data, and collective sensemaking of evidence (Honig and Venkateswaran 2012). With so much data available, however, what gets “counted” is often a result of political processes across multiple levels of the education system, as some levels need aggregate data while others need individualized data (Goren 2012).

With data having different uses across different levels of the bureaucracy, such information is often not just a passive measure of outcomes; it can also be an active factor for the achievement of these outcomes. Policymakers have used various types of information to influence classroom practices, particularly as they used incentives and sanctions to drive schools to improve student performance (Ingersoll and Collins 2017). School and teacher accountability policies often rely on information such as standardized test results to encourage schools to improve. Although studies have shown their positive impact on student achievement through the greater focus on instruction and improvement (Carnoy and Loeb 2002; Chiang 2009; Figlio and Loeb 2011), other studies have shown their negative impact in terms of teachers cheating, focusing instruction to those near the cutoff, and experiencing stress and pressure (Jacob and Levitt 2003; Neal and Schanzenbach 2010; Ryan et al. 2017). Thus, an organizational analysis must interrogate how the *form* of information organization can lead to gaming strategies or improvements in instruction (Figlio and Getzler 2006). Moreover, such an analysis must not just look at individual teachers improving teaching or deciding to cheat, but also how the organizational environments fosters such individual improvement or cheating (Hibel and Penn 2020). In this way, an organizational lens emphasizes how data are used both for measurement and for behavior change, which may have unintended consequences if not designed well.

With different ways of structuring data, this formal organization of information in schools can be consequential in both positive and negative ways. On the one hand,

information can be so critical that it can save lives as in the case of school shootings in the United States. Fox and Harding (2005) powerfully show how the loss of information contributed to schools' inability to address students with heightened emotional needs. This "structural secrecy"—that is, teachers and counselors only having a small piece of information about students—led to losing information on students who needed attention (Fox and Harding 2005: 82). On the other hand, critical scholars also note the risks of techno-surveillance in education, particularly in terms of privacy, data marketization, and oppressive algorithms that target people of color (Benjamin 2019; Hope 2015, 2016). Thus, the organization of information—what data are collected, by whom, for what purposes, and with what consequences—is a key place to interrogate how such organizational structures can impact OTL and systems improvement.

Network Perspective

Formal organizational structures are peopled, that is, these structures are interpreted and acted upon by individuals. Many organizational structures do not necessarily work as they were intended because of the networks of actors that interpret, interact, resist, adapt, and revise these structures. In this section, I focus on the "informal" aspects of organizations, that is, shared behaviors and actions that are not formal rules or stated expectations. This network perspective highlights the roles of collective interpretation, interpersonal interactions, shared implementation, social capital, and cultural capital in realizing organizational structures.

While the structural perspective often investigates the impact of an organizational structure on student outcomes (see Figure 6, gray section), the network perspective highlights *how* these structures come about through individuals' sensemaking that impact their collective interpretation and interactions, which then influence how they implement or resist these structures in schools (see Figure 6, bottom section). More importantly, an organizational perspective highlights how student and school outcomes are influenced by the social capital of individual students and the school. Structures are often also aligned to advantage certain sectors of society, who then draw on their cultural capital to gain academic advantages (see Figure 6, top part). I describe these aspects below to illustrate how schools can be studied from a network perspective.

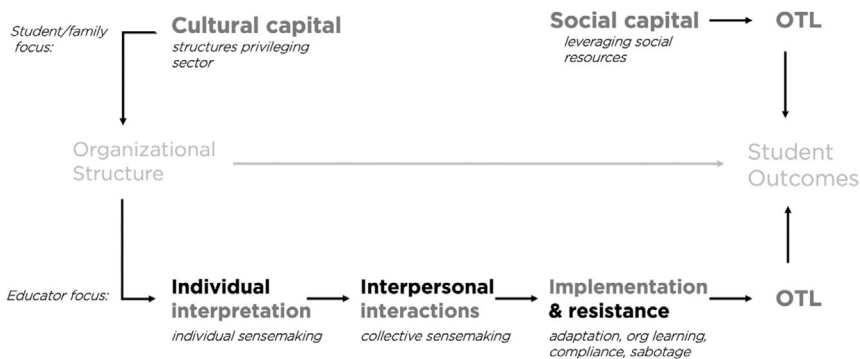


Figure 6 Network perspective.

Organizational structures and policies are interpreted by school actors like principals, teachers, staff, and students. Sociologists and education researchers have often referred to this as *sensemaking*, when people give meaning to collective experiences to inform or constrain their identities and actions (Weick, Sutcliffe, and Obstfeld 2005). In organizations, actors interpret and “make sense” of policies, processes, and group cultures (Brown, Colville, and Pye 2015), and in schools in particular, teacher sensemaking is crucial because it influences their decision on which ideas and resources—to an extent, which organizational structures—to use, appropriate, and resist (Allen and Penuel 2015). If school leaders and policy makers want programs and policies to be properly implemented, they must first engage the collective judgments, perceptions, and interpretations teachers have of these formal structures (Trinidad 2019). They have to show that these formal structures align with teachers’ needs and goals for instruction (Cohen and Mehta 2017; Penuel et al. 2007). In schools where educators are often in close everyday contact with each other, the line between individual and collective sensemaking can often be blurred.

Such individual interpretations fueled by interpersonal interactions can have consequences for the implementation of or resistance to policies. To implement structures, it is not enough to have a well-designed policy. One needs social networks of local experts that improve collective capacity and encourage adoption (Frank, Zhao, and Borman 2004). Teachers’ informal ties, networks, and interactions can affect organizational reform and instructional improvement. Often, the main mechanism for change is through the flow of resources and expertise within the social network (Penuel et al. 2009). However, such ties may also have negative consequences, particularly if they lead to cliquish exclusion and barriers to interaction among teachers (Payne 2008). These studies highlight that organizational change does not merely happen when policies directly influence individual teachers’ instructional habits. Rather, it happens when school actors positively interpret structures, leverage network expertise, and conform to social pressures for improvement. Of course, such networks can also prevent school structures from being realized, particularly when top-down efforts come in conflict with realities on the ground (Hallett 2010; Ingersoll 1996). In this way, the interpretation, interactions, and implementation of educators on the ground can have proximal impacts on students’ OTL, which then influence the outcomes in schools.

Networks are not just operative among educators and school leaders but also among students and their families. Students’ outcomes can be affected by their ability to leverage and draw on their social resources (Lin 2001). On the one hand, *social capital* can be an individual characteristic for one’s ability to access resources through social relationships (Burt 2004; Lin 2001). On the other hand, social capital can be understood as a communal characteristic highlighting shared expectations, information flows, social norms, and collective goals (Coleman 1988). In either case, scholars have argued that greater social capital can positively influence students’ outcomes and life trajectories. For example, one summer school program prepared low-income students for elite boarding schools not simply through classroom instruction but also through the creation of horizontal social networks with their cohort and vertical social networks with their mentors, all done to gain academic support and information to persevere in their future schools (Cox 2017). In the case of families, social capital can be built when families in the same schools communicate effectively, share expectations, and enforce similar norms, which have been argued to boost student achievement (Coleman 1988; Gamoran et al. 2021).

Aside from social capital, *cultural capital* is also a key concept investigated in sociology. Cultural capital is defined as “high status cultural signals used in cultural and social selection” (Lamont and Lareau 1988:153), with consequences in education if schools’ standards are more aligned with a particular class in society (Lareau and Weininger 2003). Because students’ cultural capital—often the result of one’s rearing at home—can align or conflict with a school’s subtle organizational expectations, some students are privileged while others are disadvantaged by this setup (Lareau and Weininger 2003). In this way, the school organization can reveal *who* has cultural capital. This may happen for students as middle-class grade schoolers more readily request for help, receive them, and thus create advantages for themselves as compared to their working-class peers (Calarco 2011). Such may also operate through parents, particularly as greater parental involvement and monitoring are aligned with schools’ expectations for how parents should engage in their child’s education (Lareau 1987). While parents’ social class can affect their participation in school activities, more recent research shows that when parents in disadvantaged communities are in well-connected networks, it can encourage parents’ active involvement in schools (Li and Fischer 2017), suggesting that class does not wholly predict cultural capital. An important aspect for investigation is how the alignment of cultural capital and organizational structures came as a result of intentional action on the part of privileged sectors of the society. Taken altogether, this section on the network perspective provides a lens to show the mechanisms by which networks of educators, students, and families can impact student outcomes and school systems.

Ecological Perspective

Although the typical view of organizational research is to understand what happens within schools, studies have also viewed the school in its larger context. Schools are part of a *horizontal* ecology of other schools that interact with each other, a *vertical* ecology of different levels of education governance, and a *community* ecology that includes other organizations and institutions sustaining schools: local neighborhoods, political offices, and the school improvement industry. In studying these ecologies, researchers may understand the distal drivers of inequality, institutionalization, and innovation in education. Figure 7 illustrates the various ecologies that impact what happens inside schools, which include the horizontal ecology of other schools, the vertical ecology of the hierarchical education bureaucracy, and the community ecology that includes neighborhoods, political institutions, and “outside” improvement organizations.

Inequalities in the Horizontal Ecology

Schools coordinate and compete. On the one hand, schools and their administrators look to one another for decisions, actions, and legitimation of their practices (Jennings 2010). School leaders often look to other schools in their sector for new instructional practices, use of performance metrics, and particular school structures like class size and staff credentials (Davies and Quirke 2007). But on the other hand, schools also implicitly and explicitly compete for student enrollment, district funding, school achievement, and high-quality students. Organizational studies have focused on this competition among schools, particularly with charter schools where funding depends on the number of student (Berends 2015; Oberfield 2017). Such competition can at times entail inter-school differentiation when resources are widely available, and conformity when institutional resources are low (King, Clemens, and Fry 2011).

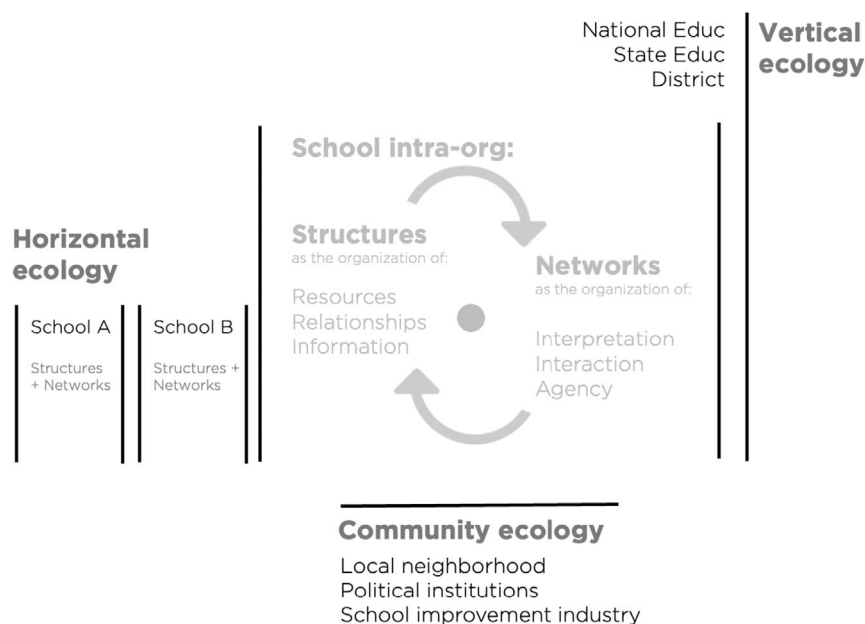


Figure 7 Ecological perspective.

Educational sociologists often study the horizontal ecology of schools not just because of the dynamics of coordination and competition, differentiation and isomorphism; but also because of the attendant *inequalities* that arise in this ecology, particularly as school demographics reflect and shape neighborhood residential segregation based on social class and race (Burdick-Will et al. 2020; Keels and Keene 2013). In the process of competition, schools may privilege recruiting certain “high-quality” students (Jennings 2010) or project an image that caters to white middle-class families leading to charter schools’ racial and class-based segregation (Haber 2021). Similarly, families’ choice also affects the horizontal ecology such as when White families move to charter schools when public school districts become racially integrated (Renzulli and Evans 2005), when they manipulate categories like disability to create de facto segregation in a district that was supposedly desegregated (Saatcioglu and Skrtic 2019), or when non-poor students left probationary schools for another district or for private schools but poor students transferred out only to move to an equally low-performing urban school (Rich and Jennings 2015). Such examples show why the horizontal ecology of schools remains a key site for investigation for educational sociologists, and more recent studies are using computational, geographic, and novel statistical models to investigate school choice sets and student mobility (Burdick-Will et al. 2020; Haber 2021).

Other factors that influence this horizontal ecology include resources and the presence of other school organizations. In a study of the performance of public vis-à-vis private schools, Arum (1996) finds that public school students in states with a large private school sector had improved educational outcomes. However, such improvements were not so much because of organizational efficiency but because of the increased resources put in by the

public sector (Arum 1996). Such dynamics are also evident with the emergence of charter schools, particularly as more resources are being expended toward this new organizational form (Renzulli 2005). Given that public school opening and closure are becoming more prevalent (Caven 2019; Ewing 2018), studies should interrogate more closely the factors leading to such changes in the horizontal ecology of schools.

Institutionalization in the Vertical Ecology

Different levels of the education bureaucracy create structures of control and accountability. Organizational actors in federal, state, and district education offices create policies and make decisions that affect schools instituting similar practices (Diehl and McFarland 2015). While classic studies have argued that the internal organization of the school is “loosely coupled” and buffered from the technical demands of the institution (Meyer and Rowan 1977; Weick 1976), more recent research has shown that changes in policies have led to structures being recoupled through accountability systems (Hallett 2010). If the educational bureaucracy creates a policy and applies it to all schools, this can lead to similar practices shared among different schools. However, such practices can look marginally or significantly different across schools, depending on the ways grounded actors resist, co-opt, or adapt these bureaucratic policies.

As lawmakers or district personnel institute policies like test-based accountability, both positive and negative practices—for example, focused instruction or gaming scheme—also become institutionalized (Jennings 2005; Neal and Schanzenbach 2010). Through their laws and policies, state education bureaucracies can affect coercive isomorphism, where schools become more similar with each other as a function of the demands to conform to the larger institution (DiMaggio and Powell 1983). Yet these do not just happen through formal channels since even informal responses—like gaming strategies—can be isomorphic outcomes of changes in the vertical ecology. Organizational studies of the vertical ecology of the education bureaucracy can attend to the formal and informal ways by which ideas and practices become institutionalized by various levels of the bureaucracy.

Innovation and Constraint in the Community Ecology

School changes are often supported and constrained by its community ecology. The school is part of local neighborhoods, larger political institutions, and other industries. One important way sociologists think of these extra-organizational entities is in terms of how they contribute to student outcomes, exacerbate or interrupt inequalities, and facilitate or prevent educational innovations.

The school’s neighborhood may influence student outcomes through its financial and moral support of the school, its creation of opportunities, its social networks, or its lack of these resources. While research finds that long-term exposure to neighborhood disadvantage reduces the odds of high school graduation (Wodtke, Harding, and Elwert 2011), increasing resources for both schools and localities can also positively impact these academic outcomes (Hofflinger and von Hippel 2020). But it is not merely about material resources since other forms of educational inequalities may be exacerbated because of neighborhood conditions: A neighborhood school’s racial composition still often affects students’ long-term outcomes (Gamoran, Collares, and Barfels 2016); parents create race-based boundaries through their neighborhood contexts (Kruse and Kroneberg 2019); and neighborhood gentrification and improvement have little effect on public school achievement (Keels and Keene 2013).

While neighborhoods affect schools, larger political communities and histories also change trajectories that support or constrain school improvement. Changes in social norms, city leadership, national legislation, and even histories of colonization are distal factors that affect organizational changes. For example, research suggests that school reforms are affected by changing political institutions and social paradigms—manifest in governmental infrastructure, legislation, and public clamor (Cohen and Mehta 2017; Mehta 2013). As a global example, organizational practices like early-grade tracking and high-stakes exams have also changed—that is, reduced—in countries that became more liberalized (Furuta 2020) but have stagnated in countries with a history of Western colonization (Furuta 2021). Such studies show wider conceptions of ecology and how different political and state organizations can contribute to changes in the school's functioning. Rather than think of these as macrosocial factors, sociologists should view them as different organizations (e.g., state and individual schools) interacting with each other.

Finally, the community ecology does not only refer to the concentric circles of place-based institutions; they also refer to industries involved in the functioning of schools. In his review, Arum (2000) suggests the idea of school communities as not only neighborhood characteristics but also organizational fields of market competition, state regulation, and professional associations (the first two are what I refer to as horizontal and vertical ecologies). He noted how these institutional and organizational environments shape and transform schools, and how they afford schools possibilities for innovation and development (Arum 2000). An even broader conceptualization is suggested by Rowan (2002, 2006), who highlighted the school improvement industry that includes for-profit publishers, nonprofit organizations, higher education institutions, and teacher professional associations. Since these education-related institutions provide schools with information, teacher training, book materials, test kits, and programming, they are crucial in inhibiting or encouraging organizational change and innovation (Rowan 2002). More recent research has highlighted the role of “school improvement organizations,” that include research partners, philanthropies, school support organizations, and intermediary actors (Burch 2007; Trinidad 2023).

Using an Integrated Organizational Lens to Study Education

To summarize, I offer four tenets for an integrated organizational sociology of education: (1) Organization refers to both the school entity and the school process, and such organization has implications for the core task of instruction and the core outcome of student learning. (2) The structural perspective investigates how the organization of resources, formal relationships, and information can influence opportunities to learn, which bring about student outcomes. (3) The network perspective highlights how informal interactions and interpretation can affect implementation of practices as well as how social and cultural capital can influence outcomes and organizational structures. (4) The ecological perspective emphasizes how other schools (horizontal dimension), the education bureaucracy (vertical dimensions), and other organizations outside schools (community dimension) can distally influence school inequalities, innovation, and institutionalized practices.

The concepts of structures, networks, and ecologies provide researchers with a cognitive map for studying educational issues. By having an *organizational* perspective, researchers can view key educational sociology topics—like inequality, segregation, school choice, school violence, dropping out, or policy intervention—not as abstract social forces but as proximate, varied, and relational processes that affect the core work of instruction and human development. It

highlights that these topics are grounded in intra- and inter-organizational contexts with individuals as active agents, at times constrained by organizational arrangements while at other time supported by these arrangements. By using this *integrated* perspective, sociologists and education researchers may uncover gaps in studying school problems, connect literatures previously disconnected, and suggest solutions that span different levels of analyses.

What then should researchers do? First, researchers should seriously look at the school organization as both site and driver of social action (Powell and Brandtner 2016), rather than simply as a fixed effect to control for inter-school variation. Second, researchers can attend to the micro-politics within and between schools, particularly the roles and interests of different groups like policymakers, union leaders, parents, and students. Third, studies can view the different levels of an open system: classroom interactions, school dynamics, district policies, and other implicated organizations. For example, a problem like teacher turnover is inchoately explained by either structural teacher shortages or individualistic accounts of burnout (see Ingersoll 2001); it needs to be explained through intra-school systems and peer networks affecting burnout, inter-school/district movement, or alternative careers outside schools. Thus, this framework of structures, networks, and ecologies helps researchers deconstruct the various aspects of school issues, ask new questions, or answer old ones in new ways.

In terms of methodologies, this organizational sociology of education uses and incorporates diverse traditions. Quantitatively, studies use experimental and quasi-experimental designs to evaluate policies and programs, hierarchical models to understand variations across levels, and moderation or mediation models to confirm theorized pathways (Hong 2015; Morgan 2013; Raudenbush and Bryk 2002). Other research questions are answered through social network data, computational methods, and dynamic datasets (Burdick-Will et al. 2020; Haber 2021; Penuel et al. 2009). Qualitatively, studies use school ethnographies, interviews with school actors, document analysis of district meetings, between-case comparisons, and historical documentation (Coburn and Russell 2008; Ewing 2018; Mehta and Davies 2018). Future research can explore how the organizational perspective can complement research on social stratification, randomized controlled trials, program evaluation, and policy reform analysis (see introduction for ideas).

Several implications flow from this integrated perspective. Although the common view is that schools are set structural entities, researchers must view them as organizations in process: at times changing and changed, but at other times continuing previous processes and inequalities albeit in different forms. Although many studies view networks as happening *in* organizations, researchers should show how networks are a function *of* the organizations they are part of. Although research assumes the ecological factors as merely macro-social forces affecting schools and students, researchers should view these ecologies as unique sets of organizations interacting with the school organization. Finally, while sociological studies often privilege rigorous empirical specificity, researchers must not ignore the critical work of theorizing an integrative view of the organization of schools.

This essay maps out the terrain for an organizational sociology of education, and it provides a high-level map for interrogating anew topics in education. The challenge is for social scientists to view problems organizationally, to uncover gaps given the suggested integrated perspective, to leverage methods attentive to organizational variation, and to suggest solutions sensitive to the interaction of structures, networks, ecologies, and human agency.

Conflict of Interest

The author declares no conflict of interest.

ENDNOTES

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